In the Bala Hisar, Shah Shuja, understanding the vital importance of an immediate response before the insurgency gained any more momentum, was increasingly baffled by the failure of Macnaghten to counter-attack: it was not just self-defeating, it was also such a stark contrast to the way he had been so keen to manage every minute detail of Afghanistan's governance in peacetime. Yet, parallel to all the frantic activity in the city, the British leadership within the cantonment remained strangely quiescent, as if frozen with fear. As Herati put it, 'His Majesty eventually sent his Chief Secretary to Macnaghten in the cantonment with the message that: "Now is no time for idleness or delay! Send troops at once to invest the city from all sides and quell this riot before it swells to unmanageable proportions; arrest the leaders before they get fully organised – it can still be done!"' Herati went on:

> Macnaghten – alas – thought His Majesty over-nervous, and merely sent one platoon of Tilingas [sepoys] with artillery to the Bala Hisar fort to calm the royal nerves. His Majesty again sent an urgent message: 'We are currently quite safe in the Bala Hisar fort; but the utmost urgency is security in the city, which must be restored at once, otherwise these turbulent townsmen will never be tamed!' Macnaghten's only answer was: 'Why all this hurry?' If only Macnaghten had followed His Majesty's advice, and had sent immediately some proper English troops to invest the city from all sides, and to make an example of the ring-leaders by burning down their houses, they would have struck the fear of God into the rioters and restored order! As it was, Macnaghten dithered, while His Majesty had only his small personal guard and had to bend to his will.[31]

British eyewitnesses within the cantonment also recorded the degree to which Macnaghten misread the seriousness of what was going on, despite the shocking murder of his deputy. 'Macnaghten at first made light of the insurrection,' recorded Vincent Eyre, 'and by his representations as to the general feelings of the people towards us, not only deluded himself, but misled the General. The unwelcome truth was however soon forced on us.'[32] Indeed, by early afternoon, rather than counter-attacking, Macnaghten had instead decided to retreat, abandoning his outlying Mission Compound and withdrawing his civil headquarters into the cantonment. Elphinstone meanwhile had ordered the guard along the cantonment walls to be doubled. Beyond that, no action was taken by the British commanders despite having 5,000 armed soldiers, ample horse artillery and a year's store of ammunition at their disposal. 'We must see what the morning brings,' Elphinstone wrote to Macnaghten, 'and then think what can be done.'[33] The formidable Lady